Chapter 8

# *Queering the Map*

## On designing digital queer space

*Lucas LaRochelle*

### Introduction: a crooked tree

There is a tree in Parc Jeanne-Mance in Tiotiàh:ke/Montréal that grows crooked. Rather than continuing along a linear path, it deviates, searching for an alternative route towards the sun. I have a particular attachment to this tree, as it is where I first met someone that I would eventually fall in love with. In its presence, I am transported back to the impressions of our first encounter—an isolated moment of queer love in the making. Simultaneously, this tree holds the memory of an explosive conversation during which I expressed that I was not a man, not a woman, but somewhere in between and somewhere far beyond. Biking past this tree one fall evening in 2017, I felt particularly overcome by these overlapping scenes of queer possibility that seemed to have lingered at that spot despite the passage of time.

As I continued my ride home, I began to plot other points of queer significance for me: the mysterious red shipping container in the woods by my childhood home, where my first love and I would meet ritualistically to discuss our feelings for each other and the barriers to their expression, as he was not out at the time; the baseball field in Parc Laurier where my friend gifted me their old pink slip, which I subsequently put on and danced around in, feeling validated in my trans* experience; the street corner where I kissed someone for what felt like hours, filled with both the excitement of the encounter and the fear of being harassed for such a public display of queer affection.

The overcoming rush of these recollections prompted me to create a way to map these moments, to make them visible outside of my individual experience. I wanted to better understand how others in my community and beyond it experience and do *queer*, I wanted to expand the sense of connectivity that I felt in the presence of that tree; to co-create an interlocking web of queer feeling and memory. What might it feel like to move through a digital world overflowing with queer pasts and presents, and what futures might emerge from this kind of embodied knowledge?

These musings eventually took form as *Queering the Map*: a community-generated counter-mapping platform that digitally archives queer experience in relation to physical space. The interactive map provides an interface with which

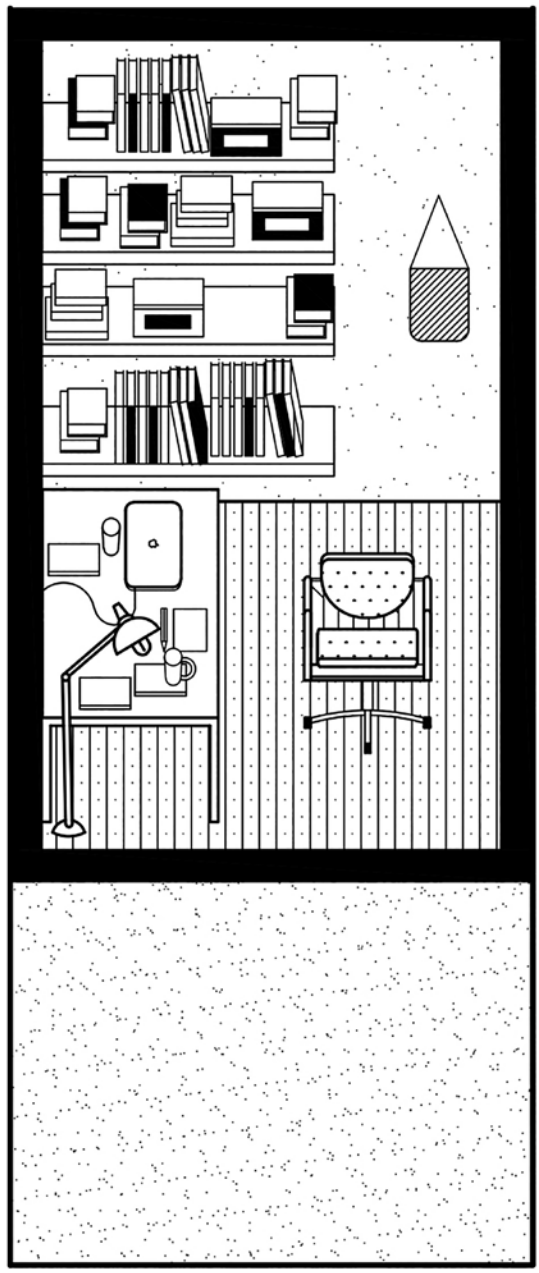


*Figure 8.1* Lucas LaRochelle's workspace. Montreal, CA.
Source: Drawing by Regner Ramos.

to collaboratively archive the cartography of queer life—from park benches to the middle of the ocean—in order to preserve queer histories and unfolding realities. From collective action to stories of coming out, encounters with violence to moments of rapturous love, *Queering the Map* functions as a living archive of queer life across the world. By mapping out LGBTQ2IA+[1] experiences in their intersectional permutations, the project works to generate affinity across difference and beyond borders.

To contribute to *Queering the Map* visitors click on a particular point in space on the map and add a text description to document their queer experience in relation to that location. Once submitted, posts are moderated for hate speech, spam, and breaches of anonymity (such as full names, phone numbers, and/or addresses); upon approval, these stories appear publicly on the map. There are no user profiles and as such, no user data is attached to the points. The only information stored in the database is the geographical coordinate, the text supplied by the contributor, and the time and date of the submission.

The aim of this chapter is to provide a critical reading of *Queering the Map* as a digital queer archive and my role as its creator. I begin by charting the trajectory and theoretical underpinnings of this practice-based project in order to situate it in relation to the critical work on queer spatialities that led to its emergence. From there, I make a case for resisting the academic impulse to *make sense* of the stories shared to *Queering the Map*, opting to reproduce a selection of them in full to assert them as agential theoretical fragments in their own right. Following this, I explore the ways in which *Queering the Map* functions as a queer map—rather than simply a map of queer stories—by discussing the decisions made in the design of its interface. Finally, I reflect on the resulting user experience(s) that emerge(s) from these choices, by describing the disorienting experience of navigating the map. Like the experience of cruising through *Queering the Map* itself, this chapter takes many twists and turns, and I invite you to get lost along the way. As I hope to show you through this winding path of practice, theory, and reflection—to be lost is a feature, not a bug.

## Trajectory

I launched *Queering the Map* in May of 2017, at which point it held only five pins describing my own formative experiences. That October, during my residency at the Concordia Fine Arts Reading Room, the project spread outside of my immediate networks, as I set the browsers of the public computers to open onto *Queering the Map*. Pins began popping up in places outside of Tiotiàh:ke/Montréal; first in Tkaronto/Toronto, then in Coast Salish Territories/Vancouver, in Gadigal Territories/Sydney, Australia, and then throughout what is currently known as the United States. I would check the site multiple times every day, overcome with the intensity of the stories shared, recanting them to anyone who would listen. When the residency concluded in January of 2018, there were just over 600 stories on the map.

Within a period of three days in February 2018, the site went from 300 shares to just over 10,000 shares on Facebook after having been shared by Tiotià:ke/Montréal DJ, producer, and promoter Frankie Teardrop, which increased the number of points added from 600 to about 6,500. Inevitably, with this kind of visibility and support, the project was also met with opposition. On February 11, 2018 supporters of United States President Donald Trump, spammed the platform. They injected the site with malicious JavaScript code,[2] generating pop-ups that read "Donald Trump Best President" and "Make America Great Again". While the attack came as a shock—I had not anticipated the site to reach such a large audience—I was bolstered by the community that had so quickly assembled around the fledgling platform. I immediately took the map down, and posted a call for help on the URL.

Within hours, a group of volunteer coders assembled through the digital woodwork, and the platform's codebase was moved into a GitHub[3] repository so that it could be collaboratively edited. The database was scrubbed of the malicious JavaScript code that had infected it, and measures were put into place to reduce the vulnerability of the site to similar attacks. Most notably, a moderation system was implemented so that all posts had to be screened for hate speech, spam, and breaches of anonymity before being published to the map.

On April 3, 2018, I relaunched *Queering the Map*. Since then, its growth has been overwhelming—at the time of writing, *Queering the Map* is home to over 86,000 stories of queer existence and resistance—in 23 languages—from across the world.

## A queer approach to space

The site that sparked *Queering the Map*'s emergence—the crooked tree in Parc Jeanne-Mance—lies outside of what might be commonly understood as *queer space*. It is not within the bounds of the city's Gay Village, nor is it a bookstore, a bar, or another site of consumption catering to LGBTQ2IA+ clientele. While these concrete spaces and the communities they create have social, cultural, and historical importance that cannot be understated, they were not the primary sites that came to mind when I began to chart the psychogeography of my own queer experience. Rather, the 'spaces' that had been registered as *queer* in recollection, were temporally transient moments that had reverberated with such intensity that they had marked the locations in which they had occurred. As historian George Chauncey has argued, there is "no queer space, there are only spaces used by queers or put to queer use" (1995, 224). Thought through the negation of essentialism, and towards an understanding of queer space as being fundamentally relational and contingent, the possibilities for thinking about queer space are rendered exponential.

Studies of queer geographies are increasingly responding to the necessity of moving beyond the study of 'gayborhoods', in order to encompass what critical geographer Tim Davis considers "the diversity of experiences and the multiplicity

of sites and situations in which 'sexual dissidents' create spaces of safety and visibility" (Davis 1995, 287). Queer space, conceptualized as visible spatial arrangements populated predominantly by LGBTQ2IA+ folk, has historically been positioned as antithetical to, or a transgression of, heteronormative space, argues geographer Natalie Oswin in her paper "Critical Geographies and the Uses of Sexuality: Deconstructing Queer Space" (2008, 91). Such environments, Oswin asserts, are better defined as 'gay' or 'lesbian' spaces rather than 'queer' insofar as they still rely on and uphold a distinct binary between heterosexuality/homosexuality (91). Oswin calls for a movement away from a subject-based understanding of 'queer space' and towards a 'queer' approach to space that is not anchored in fixed identity (91). Such an approach challenges essentialist notions of queer space as always "dissident space, resistant space, progressive space, colonized space, or claimed space", and expands the analysis to better include intersections of race, class and gender (95). Oswin cites geographer Catherine Jean Nash's 2006 study of Tkaronto/Toronto's Gay Village as an example of this queer methodology, in which she frames the neighborhood not as a battleground over the right to inhabit and create space as specifically non-heterosexual, but rather as "a location deeply scarred by myriad battles fought over the social, political and cultural meanings attributed to the existence of individuals interested in same-sex relationships" (2006, 2). In positioning queer space as an influx site of divergent identities in constant contestation, Nash queers what Oswin discerns as 'gay and lesbian' space away from fixed identity and towards an active, fluid approach to its characterization. The simple fact that non-heterosexual or non-cisgender people are present in a given location does not in and of itself render it queer—rather the space becomes queered through action and negotiation.

*Queering the Map* aims to move away from thinking queer space as fixed, and towards an approach to queer placemaking that is rooted in action, as responsive and in flux. A queer approach to space understands that we cannot be queer in any fixed sense, but rather that we are *doing* queer through acts of resistance. To move away from the notion of a queer space as immovable and settled, is to position queer space as something rooted in the continuous breaking down of cis-heteropatriarchal, white supremacist, colonial, classist, and ableist structures. This shift makes necessary a sustained engagement with the histories and presents of a place and its evolving political context.

## Attuning to traces

This project is particularly indebted to the queer-of-color scholarship of Sara Ahmed and José Esteban Muñoz, both of whom engage with queerness on a spatial and temporal level, considering the interplay of the body and the built environment in the production of queer and racialized subjectivities. Their work—particularly Ahmed's work on *queer phenomenology*, *queer use*, and *sticky affect*, and Muñoz's writings on *ephemera* and the lingering of *queer performance*—laid the groundwork from which *Queering the Map* emerged. I continually circle back

to their writings as the project has developed over time as a means of re-orienting myself around the thoughts from which it initially extended from, finding new directions with every return. It feels integral to name this genealogy explicitly, as *Queering the Map* would not exist had I not followed the trails that their work had illuminated.

In *Queer Phenomenology*, Sara Ahmed undertakes an analysis of the physical orientation of a sexual orientation. "A queer phenomenology" Ahmed proposes, "would involve an orientation toward queer, a way to inhabit the world that gives support to those whose lives and loves make them appear oblique, strange, and out of place" (2006, 179). Ahmed thus considers the ways in which the queer body is in relation to not only other bodies, but to objects, architectures, and social infrastructures that make themselves legible in particular ways when experienced through queer subjectivities. In discussing her experience of returning to her family home—which resonates with the residual affects of the pressures of heteronormativity—Ahmed asserts that "when bodies do not extend into space, they might feel 'out of place' where they have been given a place. Such feelings in turn point to other places, even ones that have yet to be inhabited" (2006, 12). A queer orientation is one that is displaced from—or in oblique relation with—a normative phenomenological construction of the world. Understood as such, queer—as a spatial orientation—invites a re-articulation of the built environment so as to include spaces of queer possibility. *Queering the Map* aims to hold space for these 'other places' that become 'queer spaces', at least for a brief moment, through queer acts.

For Muñoz, such *queer acts* resist an encompassing legibility, finding form in the fleeting, the experiential, the indeterminate (1996). Contrary to feminist scholar Peggy Phelan's conception of performance as that which "becomes itself through disappearance" and as having "its only life is in the present" (1993, 146), Muñoz posits that the queer act is steeped in a "potentiality [that] is always in the horizon and, like performance, never completely disappears but, instead, lingers and serves as a conduit for knowing and feeling other people" (Muñoz 2009, 113). *Queering the Map* aims to translate the lingering of these queer acts and their future dawning potentialities by locating and archiving them in virtual space. By collectively attuning to the reverberations of queer life, the users of the platform ground ephemeral traces of queerness outside of the individual, and in doing so open up new potentialities for the animation of a queer commons across spatial/temporal divides.

To queer space is to point to the limits of current realities that do not adequately consider the safety and wellbeing of marginalized bodies across intersecting identities, and in doing so, points to other possibilities. These spaces of possibility are often ephemeral, and are produced through actions that negotiate and resist dominant power structures that labor for their eradication. It is not so much the space that is queer, but rather the actions the occur within it that render it as such. Despite their ephemeral nature, these actions of resistance do not simply disappear into the ether once they have been performed, but rather linger and hold the

possibility to act as affective maps towards the queer utopian horizon (Muñoz 2009, 18). A fleeting glance of queer recognition, a T shot in a library bathroom, an MSN conversation with an anonymous online lover—these moments are themselves places of refuge. They become sites, that through the act of archiving and circulating through the public space of *Queering the Map*, might be inhabited and reanimated by others who come into contact with them.

## Un/making sense

When writing and speaking on *Queering the Map*, I struggle with the feeling that I need to respond to an academic call to *make sense* of the stories that have been shared on the platform. So much of the writing on *Queering the Map* is opaque, offering us only a partial view. To draw a clean set of conclusions would be to foreclose the complexity that each story holds as an individual narrative fragment. We don't know the full context of the stories people share; we are given only traces, glimmers, possibilities of the experiences they are transcribing. This negotiation between representation and opacity is central to the project, as the precarity of queer life in much of the world makes the obfuscation of personal identifiers a necessary safety measure. The design of the interface must then follow the logic of obfuscation and opacity, following the lives of those for whom it is intended.

In her essay "Queer OS", media theorist Kara Keeling draws attention to the hegemonic force of 'common sense' as a logic that forecloses minoritarian structures of experience lest they articulate themselves within the parameters of what is deemed perceptible to a dominant public (Keeling 2014, 153). Queer as a system of operations, she argues, "offers a way of making perceptible presently *uncommon senses* in the interest of producing a/new commons and/or of a proliferating the sense of commons already in the making" (Keeling 2014, 153, emphasis my own). *Queering the Map* functions as a commons of *uncommon senses*. It hijacks the authoritative status of the map, vandalizing it with subjective spatial histories that make space for a queer commons of feeling. Its dis-organizational strategy resists the ability to obtain an easy read, or a collapse into the systems of legibility that would qualify for 'common sense'. The single story is disrupted, making way for a promiscuously non-linear narrative, or perhaps anti-narrative.

For new media theorist Lev Manovich, the anti-narrative takes form as the database: a structural framework that "represents the world as a list of items and it refuses to order this list. In contrast, a narrative creates a cause-and-effect trajectory of seemingly unordered items (events). Therefore, database and narrative are natural enemies" (Manovich 2000, 181). *Queering the Map* functions as a database by refusing to order or 'make sense of' its contents into a linear, structured, or singular narrative. Clicking one's way through the thousands of micro-narratives that populate the site is a process of encountering the incommensurability of queer life. Rather than 'make sense' in any stable way, the Queer OS of *Queering the Map* creates a site for "forging and facilitating uncommon, irrational, imaginative, and/or unpredictable relationships between and among what

currently are perceptible as living beings and the environment in the interest of creating value(s) that facilitate right relations" (Keeling 2014, 154). The platform facilitates such relationships, or enacts a queer ethics of care towards the stories shared on it, through an organizational strategy that favors multivalent, opaque, and imperfect reads.

I want to echo this queer ethics of care in the context of this essay, by resisting the impulse to 'make sense' of the stories that populate *Queering The Map*. I don't want to theorize *on* them so much as I want to theorize *with* or *alongside* them, as they are themselves chunks of theory in the form of experience—I want to be in the world (of this essay) with them. To do so, I have opted to reproduce a few stories in full that ring with particular resonance, leaving space for these fragments to co-create meaning between each other, bumping up against one another to create contingent and contradictory readings—echoing the experience of encountering them on the platform itself.

> *Atlanta, USA*
>
> Here, visiting Atlanta as a college student, I entered my first space dedicated to black men who love men. About 1000 gay black men danced, laughed, celebrated, kissed, as beautiful erotic dancers performed and expressed their attraction to each other on stage. The party went until at least 6am. I had never felt so affirmed in my intersecting identities.

> *Terramungamine, Australia*
>
> Wiradjuri country, where my grandfather is from. Going back to country and talking with other indigenous people there, that's when I realised I'm a brother-boy.

> *Tehran, Iran (translated from Farsi)*
>
> Nine years ago, there were two boys sitting in the metro wagon facing me. The hands on eachothers neck, their eyes on eachothers eyes, and sometimes also they kissed each other's face. It was nobody's business/no one minded I was happy about them and hopeful for myself, but I did not say anything

> *Lydda/Lod, Israeli-occupied Palestinian territory*
>
> I was forced to come out to aggressive border control agents here. They denied my sexuality and were overtly homophobic. As a queer Arab woman, they saw me as a threat. The idea of Tel Aviv being a haven for LGBT+ people in the Middle East is a myth. I found greater acceptance in Palestine. Long live Palestine!

*Tiotiàh:ke/Montréal, Canada*

here, while on a skype call with MIT, I experienced lactation for the first time and as a transgender woman this was a moment I never imagined would come. trans bodies are beautiful, valuable, and 100% biologically legitimate. happy first birthday to me and my powerful trans body.

*Joe Hut, Jamaica*

I am yet to go home, to reveal my real identity. I am yet to know that home is safe and secure and that it in fact wants me. I will return one day. For QTPOC losing everything you've known and loved because of the compromise of being who you need to be is the most heart breaking thing. I fell in love with women for the first time and understood how far away I was from them when I visited just after my 15th birthday. I understood how black men stood and how my spine was no longer female. I danced with a girl in a dancehall party my cousins were throwing, her waist moved so well with mine I was sure everything in the room disappeared. I dont even know her name. But if you are queering your map too and remember an too cocky boy tekkin a wuk, thank you. Because you made me realise that moving as a man was the only way I knew to move. I guess I fell out of love with Jamaica for everything I couldn't be there. But fell in love with myself for all I will be there.

*Buenos Aires, Argentina*

Every week I pass these doors, so close to people like me. Every week I wonder if I'll ever be brave enough to step inside. For now, to know they exist and they are so close to me is enough and gives me strength.

*Mamoudzou, Mayotte*

Internet was a social revolution in this island. I met her because of internet. It was a secret relationship, the first year we met each other in the local hotels, I'll never forget the face of some people looking us when we went out to the room. . . . The second year was more secret, more difficult. Anyway, it was a wonderful experience, so hard, so strong. The queer experience made us stronger.

*Honolulu, Hawaii*

This school taught me a lot about what it means to be Hawaiian, to be queer, and to be both somewhere in between and somewhere not at all. The story of my people I was told by too many teachers left out the ancestors who loved

indiscriminate of gender and even broke beyond the binaries of it. This is where I fell in love for the first time, where my heart was broken, and where I learned that decolonization must mean queer liberation and that queer liberation must mean decolonization.

## Desiring queer interface

*Queering the Map* is not simply a map of queer stories, it is itself a queer map, a queer space. I make this distinction on the level of content versus form, in which the 'map of queer stories' represents content, and the 'queer map' represents form.[4] The content of *Queering the Map* is, of course, queer—stories of activism, fleeting glances of recognition, gender-based violence, trans-becoming, coming out, etcetera, are what populate the digital space of the map. However, what I want to draw attention to are the ways in which the interface and resulting user experience(s) of *Queering the Map* render it a *queer* map—which is to say, a map that takes queer form. The design of *Queering the Map*'s interface and resulting user experience(s) are drawn from an epistemology rooted in queer life.

Queer is a slippery and multiplicitous term, denoting non-normative gender and sexual experiences, that which is odd, strange, disruptive, and/or a theoretical refusal leveled against the pitfalls of identity politics all at once. The term's expansiveness, its contradictions, its im/possibilities, are what make it such a potent ground to work from. A queer methodology is a messy methodology, it shifts registers when you look too closely, pulling you somewhere you didn't know you could go. While I agree with the notion that there is no fixed queer space, I do think there are gestures that can be made to anticipate or design for the possibilities of queer use, or of use by a queer constituency.

The user experience(s) of dominant social media platforms such as Facebook, Instagram, and Twitter, are governed by what Iranian-Canadian writer and researcher Hossein Derakhshan calls "The Stream"—an interface typified by the endless north/south (straight) scroll of algorithmically arranged content, which is designed to keep a user in the 'cul-de-sac' of an individual social media environment for as long as possible (2015). Derakhshan decries that the early landscape of the internet—a vast distributed network of blogs extolling a multiplicity of viewpoints connected through the power of the hyperlink—has been colonized by a small conglomerate of social media environments that algorithmically govern a user's experience of the web (2015). This interface threatens the proliferation of multiple viewpoints in service of ever-polarizing thought bubbles that feed users only the content that their data profiles deem they 'want' to see. The digital space of *Queering the Map* is one ungoverned by algorithmic control. There is no system of likes, reacts, upvotes, or commenting that algorithmically privileges a certain story above others by pushing it to the top of the feed in an effort to prioritize the circulation of a specific narrative. Each addition to the map is given equal footing to the stories that come before it, further complexifying the stories pinned in proximity and on the site at large. However, because the site does not request

the users' location data, it currently loads by default in Tiotiàh:ke/Montréal, the geographic origin of the project. As a result, it is likely that stories placed there are the first to be read. Future updates of the site are set to address this bias through the implementation of a random load feature that would further decenter any one specific narrative or location.

Derakhshan's critique resonates with new media scholar D. Travers Scott's essay "Fierce.net, Imagining A Faggoty Web", which begins with a queer critique of the limitations of the drop-down menu, before exploding into a fantastical speculation on what the web could be. In it, Scott dreams of an interface that does not:

> Cram everything in so I can see it all at once, honey; I like to scroll—it's like a sashay! Zooming is a snap, I don't need some all-at-once Archimedian vantage point. I want a web I can explore, not survey, a cyberspace of cubbyholes, eddies and dark private booths. I want to zoom, rotate, slide around. . . . Think about it, imagine, it, imagine all you could do, all you could do differently, how much more such a faggot campy web could work it.
>
> (Scott 2012, 9)

Scott's essay, in its speculative excess, meets Derakhshan's critique with a desire to dream of a web that is more than what it once was, propelling us towards what it might be if we think beyond the quagmire of the digital here and now. The spatiality of the *Queering the Map* interface lends itself to resisting the linear confines of the Stream. Rather than passively scrolling along a North/South axis, agency is redistributed to the user as they drag themselves through the digital world of *Queering the Map*.

## Getting lost

*Queering the Map* queers the ubiquitous wayfinding technology of Google Maps by privileging the experience of getting lost. If the intention of a map is to orient oneself in relation to one's environment, what might it mean to orient oneself queerly? How might one get lost in relation to the colonial, Eurocentric mapping of space exemplified by the Mercator projection used by Google Maps?

Often a map is used as a means of finding something—a place that one desires to orient oneself towards. But 'finding' anything on *Queering the Map* is challenging. There is no search bar and so one cannot query a particular location nor a particular word, category, or sentiment. The process of 'finding' on *Queering the Map* is active and it is time consuming. In lieu of a search bar that automates the process of finding, one might zoom out to get a better view. But zooming out results in the blurring of thousands of stories into opaque masses, which obscure borders and converge individual narratives into collectivities. The overloading of thousands of pins obfuscates the map beneath them, as the map begins to glitch. The overloading of data occasionally causes parts of the map to not load, or to load slowly, revealing it to be nothing more than an image. It becomes hard to

use, effectively disrupting the predominant languages of cartography and digital interface, typified by objectivity and smoothness.

To locate a familiar place, one must drag themselves across the map, orienting oneself by reconstructing space through a place's relation to another. Many users add pins on *Queering the Map* divulging their inability to find or recall an exact location, marking a here, but gesturing towards a there. In some cases, these *theres* have not yet happened, but are placed as a means of marking the emergence of a possible queer future. Disorientation is the predominant mode through which one can orient themselves on *Queering the Map*. There is no one way, no specific direction through, no scroll bar to guide us. There is no neutral point of orientation.

This sense of being lost is central to the experience of navigating the digital space of *Queering the Map*. Muñoz reminds us that queerness shares a particular resonance with being lost, positing that:

> Queerness is lost in space or lost in relation to the space of heteronormativity. To accept loss is to accept queerness—or more accurately, to accept the loss of heteronormativity, authorization, and entitlement. To be lost is not to hide in a closet or to perform a simple (ontological) disappearing act; it is to veer away from heterosexuality's path. To accept the ways in which one is lost is to be also found and not found in a particularly queer fashion.
>
> (2009, 73)

## Queer user

While *Queering the Map* is a project precisely about queer experience, it is also methodologically queer in its approach to refusing the performative fixity of identity within digital spaces. As it currently stands, the majority of web platforms that host user-generated content, such as Facebook, Instagram, and Twitter, require that one create a unique and traceable profile. This profile becomes a kind of container, a set of limitations within which the user can fashion an identity for themselves. In designing *Queering the Map* I was particularly interested in exploring the generative potentials of anonymity, which is itself a queer identity in its refusal to perform fixed self-definition. Following queer theorist Eve Kosovsky Sedgwick's definition of queer as "the open mesh of possibilities, gaps, overlaps, dissonances and resonances, lapses and excesses of meaning when the constituent elements of anyone's gender, of anyone's sexuality aren't made (or can't be made) to signify monolithically" (1993, 8), I argue that the individual user profile has no domain in queer digital spaces. If the gay and lesbian (digital) space is characterized by the a priori identity of the subject (User), then the Queer User of *Queering the Map*, returning here to Oswin, is defined as such through action. The lack of the user profile on *Queering the Map* shifts the mode of engagement from *being* to *doing*, and marks a queer departure from the stability of the digital individual towards the cacophony of collectivity. The Queer User is always more than one.

Anonymity further serves as a means through which to contest 'coming out' or 'being out' as a prerequisite to participating in and articulating experiences

of queer life. The anonymous interface of *Queering the Map* places those who are out and those who are not, on more or less equal footing. In an article on the project published by *Ruthless Magazine*, writer and poet Angad Singh, who uses a pseudonym as they were not out to their family at the time of publication, reflects:

> It might sound like a strange aspiration, to be anonymous. Maybe it's also strange that a project that assigns its participants blanket anonymity provides exactly the conditions necessary to give a diverse and persecuted demographic visibility. But anonymity is distinct from invisibility. It presupposes a crowd in which to lose oneself, with which to be amalgamated. Perhaps it touches on a sense of belonging that so many of us have lacked in our formative years in an othering world. In the case of *Queering The Map*, anonymity is the basis of our ability to become known.
>
> (2018)

The anonymous participative internet user is often characterized as the troll, the kind of user who, in resisting the call for transparency and legibility, is stripped of the ability to appear legitimate. On *Queering the Map*, precisely because submissions to the project are anonymous and bear no corroborating evidence other than the subjective recounting of the ephemeral "traces, glimmers, and residues"[5] of an event, there is a deliberate refusal to play into systems of archival 'truth' that cast LGBTQ2IA+ life as always already invalid or up-for-debate. The inability to trace a submission back to user stymies the ability to validate the realness of any story posted, no way to provide 'proper' evidence as to the legitimacy of an event.

By rendering all users as anonymous informants, legitimacy becomes a flexible and free-floating term, holding space for the stories of fantasy and fabulation that populate the map, orienting us away from what is and towards what could be. For example, multiple stories pinned in the middle of the Atlantic Ocean offer us a queer reading of both *Titanic*, the film and the Titanic itself:

> *Atlantic Ocean*
>
> rose, you were so beautiful here on the RMS titanic. i couldn't believe my eyes when i first saw you. i truly hoped for the best, but alas, you were straight and fell for that poor boy jack. after the ship sunk, and we were rescued from our respective life boats, i never saw you again. i have only heard stories about your (unfortunately) heterosexual love : (i love you, rose.

> *Atlantic Ocean*
>
> reamed jacks asshole on the rms titanic but he chose her over me :/

> *Atlantic Ocean*
>
> I'm claiming the RMS Titanic for anyone who is LGBTQIA+

Submissions such as these point to a *queering* of both historical events and their cultural narrativization, reading queer possibility into spaces in which they are not represented. It is a strategy of constructing a narrative through loosely assembled fragments; a practice of reconfiguring traces, possibilities, and fantasies in order to create queer counter-narratives. Fabulation in the archive is a form of refusal that makes new futures possible. It undoes the sacrosanct project of truth-telling that both the map and the archive are set up to produce, thus *queering* the map and the archive and their masquerade as bearers of objectivity.

## Conclusion: sticky circulations

To post on *Queering the Map* constitutes a kind of giving, sharing one's own experience of finding, if only briefly, a space of queer possibility. These experiences might then allow others who come into contact with them to also 'find' themselves—reflected back, though only in fragments, in another's story. These stories can be lifelines[6]—a trace left behind by those who stand behind us, redirecting us towards the possibility of another world within the world. In trying to find something, one might get lost and stumble upon something else—something they didn't know they were looking for.

It's not so much about what is revealed, transcribed onto the digital construction of space that the map provides, but rather what continues to elude us when we return to the places that once made spaces for queerness to flourish. The stories on *Queering the Map* often speak to what was once there, rather than what continues to be visible. The stories speak to a past that has 'stuck' to a place, the particular set of circumstances and affective structures that brought into existence a particularly *queer* moment. The act of documenting these ephemeral traces ensures however that the potentiality of these individual moments never fades, offering an affective opening into each other's worlds.

*Queering the Map* continues the process of circulating these traces, by providing a space for them to stick onto those who come in contact with them. My role as the creator and steward of this platform involves reading through thousands of submissions of queer feeling, from the banal to the violent to the ecstatic, an endeavor which is at once incredibly gratifying and emotionally laborious. The stories that have been stuck on to *Queering the Map*, in turn continue to stick to me, further complexifying and reconfiguring the way I experience and move through the world. Now, as I pass the crooked tree in Parc Jeanne-Mance that served as my initial point of oblique orientation on the journey of this project, I feel not only connected to the memories it holds, but to the tens of thousands of queer experiences that have been shared to *Queering the Map* so far. In following the paths taken by those who have refused to follow the directions, I get lost, and feel found in collectivity. I find my place by being out of place.

## Notes

1 Lesbian, Gay, Bisexual, Queer, Two Spirit, Intersex, Asexual +
2 A type of attack known as Cross Site Scripting (XSS), in which the perpetrator exploits the vulnerability of a website's structure to fool it into running an external JavaScript function. It is a common form of attack on websites that allow user-generated content to be publicly displayed.
3 GitHub is a platform to host source code for version control and collaboration.
4 This question emerged during the Queering Maps roundtable at the Bartlett School of Architecture in May 2019 for which I was a panelist. This call for delineating queer form vs. content was proposed to the panelists by Rebecca Ross.
5 José Esteban Muñoz, "Ephemera as Evidence: Introductory Notes to Queer Acts," *Women & Performance: a Journal of Feminist Theory* 8, no. 2 (1996): 5–16.
6 Here I am referencing Sara Ahmed's discussion of 'lifelines' in *Queer Phenomenology*: "How ironic that "a lifeline" can also be an expression for something that saves us. A lifeline thrown to us is what gives us the capacity to get out of an impossible world or an unlivable life" (2006, 17).

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